Hugh Everett III was born on November 11, 1930, into a family with Virginia roots that stretched back generations on his father's side; his paternal great-grandfather had fought for the Confederacy in the Civil War. Everett's father, Hugh Everett Jr., was a military engineer and logistics officer whose existence revolved around the Army. His mother, Katharine, was a free-spirited writer and pacifist. She and Hugh Jr. were a bad match temperamentally and philosophically, and they divorced (scandalous, for the time) several years after Hugh III was born. Hugh grew up in Bethesda, Maryland, with his father and stepmother. His family dubbed him "Pudge," because of his somewhat stocky build; Everett hated the nickname, but it stuck with him for the rest of his life.

With his nose usually buried in a science-fiction book, Hugh showed early signs of academic talent—and a taste for paradoxes. At twelve, he wrote a letter to Einstein, claiming to have solved the question of what would happen if an immovable object met an unstoppable force. The letter is lost, but Einstein replied, saying that while unstoppable forces and immovable objects weren't real, "there seems to be a very stubborn boy who has forced his way victoriously through strange difficulties created by himself for this purpose."

A year later, Everett won a scholarship to St John's, a Catholic military prep academy in Washington, DC. There, he excelled in nearly all of his classes, even the required religious instruction, despite the fact that his vocal atheism had already earned him a new nickname: "the heretic." Everett graduated with honors in 1948 and went on to study at Catholic University, also in DC, where he studied chemical engineering and mathematics, quickly impressing his professors and classmates with his remarkable facility for math and logic.

Unsurprisingly for a talented student of logic, Everett's taste for paradoxes was still lively. His patience for his required religious instruction wearing thin, Everett challenged one of his devout professors at Catholic with a "proof" of the nonexistence of God. The professor was purportedly sent into a state of serious religious doubt and despair, to Everett's dismay. Everett wasn't particularly interested in actually convincing anyone to fundamentally shift their worldview—he just wanted to have fun. And for Everett, fun entailed gaming out the logical consequences of a statement